

Gigabyte	MSI	MSI
K8 Triton GA-K8N Pro-SLI	K8N SLI Platinum	K8N SLI-F
NVIDIA nForce4 SLI	NVIDIA nForce4 SLI	NVIDIA nForce4 SLI
34.99	33.55	33.93
AMD X2	AMD X2	AMD X2
DDR/400/4	DDR/400/4	DDR/400/2
4	4	4
2+1 PCIe	3	3+1 PCIe
Pin header 3/b	1/a	1/a
6/6	6/6	6/6
4	4	4
Dual Gigabit	Gigabit	Gigabit
0,1,0+1,5	0,1,0+1,JBOD	0,1,0+1,JBOD
II/8/4	II/4/4	II/4/4
SPDIF IN/Out	Creative Sound Blaster Live! 24-bit on-board, Coaxial and SPDIF out	Coaxial and SPDIF out
3.25	3.5	3.75
3	3	3
5	0	5
5	5	5
4/4	4/4	4/4
SATA, SATA power, IDE, floppy	2 SATA, SATA power, IDE, floppy	2 SATA, SATA power, IDE, floppy
D-bracket for 2 USB and FireWire, D-bracket for 2 USB, SLI bridge with retention bracket	D-bracket for 2 USB, SLI bridge with retention bracket	D-bracket for 2 USB, SLI bridge with retention bracket
23.60	37.12	36.73
75.13/66.42	150.87/105.59	150.24/104.95
45.6/43.2	121.1/92.6	121/92.7
5716/2626	7148/6129	7129/5923
Failed/Failed	6685/4758	6834/4760
Failed/Failed	8247/4434	8245/4431
Failed	6683	6668
3574/1679	4779/4776	4765/4766
20355/7642	20598/7608	20400/7573
45861/48630	45974/49429	45099/49380
47/8	49/8	48/10
53/34	55/38	55/36
53/39	55/42	55/41
24.9	30.4	30.4
118	113	115
5.77	4.78	6.04
9,950	12,000	9,500
64.35	75.45	76.70



+ None
- Slow performance



+ Creative Soudblaster Live! On-board
- Expensive



+ Good performance
- Ordinary package contents

GA-K8NXP-SLI with 30.9. This indicates that these two boards can rip through daily-use applications such as word processors, spreadsheets, presentations, file compression and anti-virus programs.

The Conclusion (AMD Motherboards)

The ECS KN1 Extreme was the best performer, with high scores in all the benchmarks, and was followed closely by the Gigabyte 8Σ Series GA-K8NXP-SLI.

With accessories such as the Wi-Fi 802.11 b/g card and the U-Plus DPS power system card, and lots of cables and almost all high-end features to boot, the Gigabyte 8Σ Series GA-K8NXP-SLI was the clear winner in the features department. The ASUS Proactive A8N-SLI, which also had good features and accessories, came in second.

The DFI LanParty UT NF4 was the highest-priced motherboard at Rs 15,950 which is a bit over the top, because it does not offer enough premium features or performance to justify the price tag. The nForce4 Ultra-based ASUS A8N-E was the lowest-priced—at Rs 6,750—and is actually a good value-for-money board.

After careful consideration (and calculations!), the Gigabyte 8Σ Series GA-K8NXP-SLI turned out the clear winner of the *Digit* Best Buy Gold award. The *Digit* Best Buy Silver was awarded to the ASUS Proactive A8N-SLI: it had good overall feature and performance scores, and a moderate price tag.

MOTHERBOARDS (INTEL)

Twelve motherboards that supported Intel processors were reviewed in this comparison test. Three were from ASUS, there was one each from ECS and Foxconn, two were from Gigabyte, and MSI sent in five boards.

We saw a variety of chipsets in this category. Some had Intel chipsets such as Intel 915G, 915P, 925 XE, 945G and 955X, whereas nVidia's offerings were the nForce4 Ultra and nForce4 SLI.

Over the years, Intel has reigned as the undisputed leader in chipsets for Intel processors, providing the best performance and features, and it has continued to raise the bar with each new chipset beating its predecessor. Some chipset manufacturers—Apollo, for example—have tried to beat Intel chipsets in terms of performance, but none actually did. Until now!

nVidia's nForce4 SLI Intel Edition chipsets offer better performance and features than any of the Intel chipsets out there, and as our benchmarks will show, have finally dethroned the king and have assumed top position amongst chipsets for Intel processors.

Though we did receive motherboards based on the Intel 915 and 925 chipsets, these chipsets are fast aging, and so do not stand anywhere near the newer ones—Intel's 955X, which supports dual-core processors, and the Intel 945.

The above chipsets, along with the nForce4 SLI, support an FSB of 1066 MHz. This FSB is available only with the Extreme Edition type of processors, and will truly harness the high bandwidth of DDR2 memory.